

ANGEL ACTION · MEDICAL

Diabetic Emergencies

If a person with diabetes is confused, sweaty or unwell, assume low blood sugar (hypo) and give sugary food or drink if they can swallow. Call 000 if they do not improve, lose consciousness, or seem severely dehydrated.

Hypoglycaemia (low blood sugar)

Signs: weakness, sweating, trembling, hunger, confusion, headache, slurred speech, irritable behaviour.

If conscious and able to swallow:

1. Give **sugar** — soft drink (not diet), juice, jelly beans, glucose tablets.
2. Repeat every **15 minutes** until they recover.
3. Follow with a longer-acting carbohydrate (sandwich, biscuit).
4. If no improvement, **call 000**.

If unconscious: call 000, follow **DRSABCD**, place in **recovery position**. Do NOT give anything by mouth.

Hyperglycaemia (high blood sugar)

Signs: excessive thirst, frequent urination, nausea, fruity breath, drowsiness — develops over hours or days.

- Follow **DRSABCD**.
- Help them with their own insulin if they ask.
- **Call 000** if their condition is worsening or they become drowsy.

When in doubt, give sugar

If you are unsure whether it's a hypo or a hyper, give sugar. It will help a hypo and will not significantly worsen a hyper in the short term.

Adapted from Australian First Aid 5th Edition. Get the full guide and live CPR metronome at firstaidangel.org.